The following morning, 16 October, Ulbricht congratulated Brezhnev in the warmest possible terms, but according to Vladimir Semichastny, the head of the KGB, his bitterness at being kept in the dark was palpable. He was not alone. Poland's General Secretary Wladyslaw Gomulka and Czech leader Antonín Novotný were also seething at not being informed. However, the blow was all the more painful to Khrushchev, who was wheeled into retirement, his humiliation cemented when Pravda accused him of making 'hare-brained schemes' and 'hasty decisions'.

One of the most remarkable aspects of the Khrushchev legacy was the abruptness and completeness with which it disappeared. Almost immediately, Brezhnev embarked on dismantling his predecessor's reforms in favour of a more orthodox political path. In his inaugural speech, he said that under Stalin people had feared repression, while under Khrushchev they had feared reorganisations and shake-ups, 'the Soviet people deserve a quiet life'. As he terminated Khrushchev's de-Stalinisation programme, the principal victim of events in the GDR would, over time, be Ulbricht's NES process. 'It is not unreasonable to assume that the Khrushchev thaw for the GDR, which the old Stalinist Ulbricht was uncomfortable with, was called off,' Günter Schabowski surmised.

However, nothing in the Eastern bloc happened quickly. As Brezhnev settled into office, Ulbricht ploughed on with reforms; significantly, though, Honecker cozied up to Brezhnev by lamenting Khrushchev's 'tendency towards permanent reorganisation'. Such a comment was typical, says Schabowski, as Honecker 'always and unflinchingly pursued the same goal. He was committed to the Stalinist ideas of the party and socialism. And he had an iron will.'15